

"Music lets me forget bad experiences. You cannot keep ragas and regrets in your mind together."

THE ENCHANTER

A savant of the Ganga-Jamuna tehzeeb, he was fashioned by God to serve the cause of Indian music. His swaras were for everyone, but he belonged to Varanasi alone. He may be gone, but his music plays on.

■ By Ranjana Srivastava

He was an ordinary man yet an extraordinary artiste; he was simple yet his melody was ornamental; he was a five-time namazi yet he did his sadhana in the temples of Varanasi. He was Bharat Ratna Ustad Bismillah Khan, the shehnai maestro, who took the mangal dhvani vadya to unprecedented heights. Born in Dumrao, Bihar, Khan was fashioned by God to serve the cause of Indian music. His swaras seeped into the heart and soul of the audience with moments of *ekikarana* (union).

My first memory of the Ustad goes back to the 1950s at the Allahabad music conference. When his name was announced, there was huge applause and

then hushed silence. The spell was broken by the swaras of the shehnai floating in the air. The maestro with his group of accompanists was taking long-drawn breaths to do the alap dexterously.

Khan came on the scene when the shehnai was just an instrument played on all auspicious occasions. Shehnai players would sit at the entrance of the building and play from the early hours of the morning into late night. His chief contribution was to take the instrument to the centre of the proscenium. For many years, no music conference would start without his shehnai.

The dynamics of Hindustani music has always been experimental. Khan was sensitive, creative and intelligent. He experimented with ragas on the shehnai and his success story starts from here. He caught the eye of classical artistes

and connoisseurs. He was also fully aware of the impact of Indian cinema. At a time when not many wanted to be associated with it, he was bold enough to do so.

He was generous and promoted many artistes by playing duets with them. In an era when performing artistes were moving towards metropolitan centres and the West for better opportunities, Khan decided to stay on in his own city. He would tour foreign countries, yet would always return to the banks of the river Ganges. A savant of the Ganga-Jamuna tehzeeb, his music was for everyone. But he belonged to Varanasi alone. Today the lute is silent. The Ustad sleeps peacefully in the Fatiman in Varanasi. But his music plays on.

The author is former dean, faculty of performing arts, Banaras Hindu University

Bismillah Khan

Shehnai player 1916-2006



Q: Which Hindu deity was Khan a devotee of?

A: Goddess Saraswati

Q: Which was the only movie in which he acted?

A: Jalsaghar by Satyajit Ray

Q: What, according to him, was his only vice?

A: He smoked Wills cigarettes